Teaching Statement

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Teaching should not be regarded as secondary to research within higher education. A faculty member with an extensive research record who is unwilling or unable to invest the effort required to communicate knowledge effectively, help students connect with it, understand its value, and develop a genuine interest in learning may be an excellent researcher, but not a complete scholar. The significance of knowledge lies not only in individual research achievements but in its transmission, application, and contribution to society. Whatever weight a university assigns to teaching, its educational mission rests on a shared purpose: cultivating students' research abilities and their capacity to apply knowledge to societal challenges. This statement describes how I pursue that purpose in the classroom, and how I believe it must be rethought in the age of artificial intelligence.

Teaching Experience and Student-Centered Learning

Generative artificial intelligence became widely available only during the later stages of my doctoral training. Before 2024, my teaching therefore relied primarily on flipped-classroom activities, real-time polling tools, and student-centered analyses of research questions. These approaches were designed to move students beyond the passive reception of information and encourage them to participate actively in interpreting, applying, and discussing knowledge.

For example, when I served as the instructor for *Politics of Global Governance*, students examined the historical development of global governance, major theories of international relations, and the complex networks of interdependence that emerged after the Cold War. I used classroom discussions, case study analysis, reading quizzes, policy-report proposals, and final reports to assess students' interests, comprehension, and learning outcomes. Students were free to apply approaches taught in the class, such as rational choice theory, constructivism, realism, principal–agent theory, and networked governance, to the analysis of real-world problems in global governance and public policy. In *Data Fluency*, I designed an in-class "talk-and-trace" social network activity to introduce relational data through direct student participation. Students moved around the classroom, spoke with several classmates, recorded the names of those with whom they interacted, and entered the resulting connections into a shared dataset. I then used the class-generated network to demonstrate how ordinary social interactions can be transformed into relational data, visualized as a network, and analyzed in terms of nodes, ties, and patterns of connection. This activity helped students understand that data are not abstract structures created only by researchers, but representations of relationships that emerge from everyday behavior. Students also developed original semester-long data projects, which I describe below because they illustrate how I now teach design thinking alongside technical skills.

The purpose of these activities was not simply to evaluate whether students could recall theoretical concepts. Rather, I sought to train them to determine which theories were most appropriate for explaining particular problems, compare the strengths and limitations of competing explanations, and apply abstract concepts to concrete cases. For me, teaching and learning are mutually reinforcing processes. This occurs not only while preparing course materials, but also through interaction with students, classroom discussion, and the reading and evaluation of their work. Students often raise perspectives that differ from those found in the existing literature, prompting me to reconsider how theories are understood, communicated, and applied.

Teaching Challenges in the Age of Artificial Intelligence

The rapid development and widespread adoption of generative artificial intelligence require university instructors to reconsider both teaching strategies and assessment practices. Artificial intelligence offers substantial convenience, but it also allows students to answer reading questions, prepare literature analyses, and produce polished and apparently reflective essays without having closely engaged with the assigned materials. The worst outcome occurs when students copy AI-generated material without reading, interpreting, or reflecting on it; under these circumstances, little meaningful learning takes place. Yet even students who do read AI-generated summaries may fail to understand the complete logic of an argument if they never engage with the original source, and without that engagement they cannot build the disciplinary knowledge necessary to evaluate the accuracy, originality, and practical value of AI-generated content.

This transformation also makes a longstanding question in political science and international relations more visible: what is the practical value of the knowledge we teach? Because most undergraduates will not become professional political scientists, they may struggle to see how our discipline relates to future employment or material well-being, especially now that artificial intelligence can provide answers, organize information, and perform portions of analytical work on demand. Just as the invention of the calculator made repetitive arithmetic less central to education, the development of artificial intelligence requires us to reconsider what students genuinely need to learn and which forms of reasoning should not be delegated to AI, and to redesign our teaching around them.

From Technical Training to Design Thinking

When I taught *Data Fluency* in 2025, I covered research methods, data structures and analysis, machine learning, data visualization, and research communication. At the same time, I emphasized that in the age of artificial intelligence, one of the most important cross-disciplinary abilities is design thinking grounded in prior disciplinary and scientific knowledge.

By design thinking I mean a human-centered, iterative approach to problem-solving: the ability to frame a meaningful question before reaching for a tool, to prototype an imperfect first analysis and improve it through successive rounds of feedback, and to design the final product around the needs of a real audience. The student data projects in *Data Fluency* were structured as exactly this kind of cycle. Students defined their own research questions on topics ranging from AI use, athlete injury and performance, coffee and health, mental health and lifestyle, the NBA, self-tracked gym behavior, social media advertising and engagement, student academic stress, and global sports finance. They assembled and cleaned their own data, revised their analyses through feedback, and communicated their findings in short recorded video presentations designed for broader audiences. To support this final stage, I taught students to structure presentations through a beginning–middle–end narrative and encouraged a "tree-talk" approach, in which a central takeaway is introduced early and then developed through supporting evidence rather than withheld until the end. Artificial intelligence could assist students at every stage of these projects, from debugging code to suggesting visualizations and polishing prose, but the decisions that determined whether a project succeeded were the ones AI could not make for them: whether the question was worth asking, whether the data could answer it, and how the result should be communicated.

This is why disciplinary knowledge remains the foundation of design thinking. Students require sufficient domain knowledge to understand the intellectual context, data conditions, and assumptions under which artificial intelligence generates an answer, and to identify content that is unreasonable, inaccurate, or inappropriate for a particular application. Put simply: a person who does not know what a swan is cannot ask why some swans turn out to be black.

Artificial intelligence can substantially improve efficiency by assisting with tasks that previously required considerable time, labor, or financial resources, including debugging, editing, literature searches, preliminary data organization, and coding. In the past, such assistance was often available only to researchers with substantial funding or access to research assistants; today, undergraduate and graduate students can obtain similar support at relatively low cost. For this reason, I view the development of artificial intelligence as a democratization of information analysis and research resources, and this is, overall, a positive development. Its benefits, however, depend on students possessing the abilities that cannot be delegated. As artificial intelligence absorbs more of the execution of research, including coding, summarizing, searching, and formatting, the distinctly human contribution shifts upstream to problem definition and downstream to judgment and communication. These are precisely the abilities that design thinking trains, and they now sit at the center of my methods teaching.

Teaching Principles for the Age of Artificial Intelligence

As a university instructor, I believe that the following three principles are especially important in the age of artificial intelligence: **1) Continue strengthening the connection between classroom knowledge and real-world problems.** Instructors should connect theories and methods to actual policy problems and students' lived experiences so that students can recognize the practical value of what they are learning and develop an intrinsic motivation to engage with the material. When students understand why a theory or method matters, they are more likely to be motivated to consult original documents and compare them with AI-generated summaries, interpretations, and conclusions. **2) Continue using student-centered and flipped-classroom approaches.** Within an inclusive classroom environment, students should be encouraged to become active participants in their own learning. Individual and group activities can help them formulate questions, exchange perspectives, and construct arguments. Students should also be able to participate through multiple modes, including public discussion, anonymous responses, and small-group activities, depending on their learning needs and preferred forms of expression. These approaches can increase participation while preventing classroom discussion from being dominated by a small number of more outspoken students or those with greater prior knowledge. **3) Redesign assessment to distinguish AI-generated output from students' actual understanding.** Courses may permit the use of artificial intelligence, but they should also include mechanisms for determining whether students have genuinely understood and absorbed the relevant knowledge. In addition to traditional written examinations, instructors can use interactive platforms such as Top Hat to assess students' comprehension in real time. Students can answer questions, express opinions, or indicate confusion through the application without being required to speak publicly.

Instructors can also use short in-class responses or analytical exercises in which students explain concepts, compare theories, or analyze cases without access to artificial intelligence. The purpose of these assessments is not to prohibit AI entirely. Rather, it is to create an inclusive learning environment that offers students multiple ways to express their understanding while enabling instructors to evaluate both their independent knowledge and their ability to use AI responsibly as a learning tool.

Inclusive Teaching, Continuous Learning, and Self-Reflection

Established principles of effective teaching remain essential in the age of artificial intelligence. These include inclusive teaching, micro-affirmations, student-centered learning, connections between academic knowledge and lived experience, scaffolded and incremental learning design, flipped-classroom activities, and the use of digital learning tools. Artificial intelligence has changed how students obtain information and complete assignments, but it has not changed their fundamental need to be understood, encouraged, guided, and given opportunities to participate in a safe learning environment.

As Co-Chair of the department's Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Justice Committee, I supported practices that valued the perspectives and experiences of faculty, staff, graduate students, and undergraduate students. This experience strengthened my commitment to inclusive classrooms and to ensuring that students with different backgrounds, personalities, and learning styles have meaningful opportunities to participate and express their views.

I will continue to participate in the CIRTL Network and in teaching workshops organized by APSA, ISA, MPSA, and other professional associations. These opportunities will allow me to learn new instructional approaches and tools and to revise my courses in response to changes in students' needs and the broader technological environment.

As an instructor, I genuinely enjoy helping students solve problems, observing their intellectual growth, and supporting them as they explore future academic and professional directions. This commitment was an important reason I left several years of work in think tanks and the policy sector to pursue doctoral research and interdisciplinary teaching training. My goal is to connect practical experience with academic research, help students develop an interest in political science and international relations, and show them the value of these fields for understanding the real world.

In teaching *Politics of Global Governance* and *Data Fluency*, students consistently recognized my willingness to provide assistance, my concern for their understanding, and my effort to connect course materials to real-world issues. At the same time, I understand that effective teaching requires continuous reflection and improvement. Some students noted that the pace of instruction was occasionally too fast in quantitative methods or programming-related courses, or that certain slides were covered without sufficient explanation. I take these constructive comments seriously and view them as important areas for continued improvement. In future methods courses, I will be more deliberate about slowing the pace of difficult material, providing additional examples and exercises, and using real-time feedback to confirm that students are following the course.

Contributions to the Department

I am confident that my research training, teaching experience, commitment to student learning, and understanding of higher education in the age of artificial intelligence will allow me to help students develop theoretical knowledge, methodological skills, and an awareness of real-world problems. I would also be prepared to contribute to a broad range of courses across different levels and areas of the department. Courses I am prepared to teach include:

Substantive Courses

Introduction to Political Science
Introduction to International Politics
International Organizations
Global Governance
International Political Economy
Foreign Policy Analysis
East Asian Politics
U.S.–China Relations
Chinese Foreign Policy
Taiwanese Politics

Methods Courses

Research Methods
Computational Social Science
Social Network Analysis
`R` for Political Data Analysis
AI-Assisted Research Design

Specialized Seminars

Networked World Politics
Informal International Organizations
Asia-Pacific Regional Governance
International Diplomacy in Theory and Practice

Appendix: Supplementary Teaching Materials

Teaching Evaluations

Data Fluency (Fall 2025)	• Course rating: **4.1/5**; department average: 4.1/5 • Instructor rating: **4.2/5**; department average: 4.3/5 • More than 95% of respondents would recommend the course and instructor • [Full Report] and [Syllabus]
Politics of Global Governance (Summer 2023)	• Course rating: **5/5**; department average: 4.0/5 • Instructor rating: **5/5**; department average: 3.9/5 • Strongest evaluations; results should be interpreted with caution because of the limited response rate • Listed in the evaluation system as *Politics in the Developing World* • [Full Report] and [Syllabus]

Selected Student Testimonials from the Courses

- "He released countless study resources to help us be successful on the exam. Additionally, he is helpful in extending deadlines and meeting the students where they need. I was fortunate to have such a caring professor."
- "I liked how much he related it to the real world and how nice he was to everyone."
- "The instructor genuinely cared about whether we understood the content. They broke things down in a simple way and always connected lessons to real-life examples, which made the material more interesting."
- "Mr. Wang is nothing short of an exceptional empathetic person here to help."
- "The instructor is so extremely approachable and kind. He has been more than generous in accommodating summer schedules. I also like that he tells us when he is also learning about emerging research in this field."